

Rheumatology Waiting Times – What You Can Do

NHS rheumatology waiting times can be months long. UK guide to what you can do while waiting, how to get seen faster, and self-management strategies.

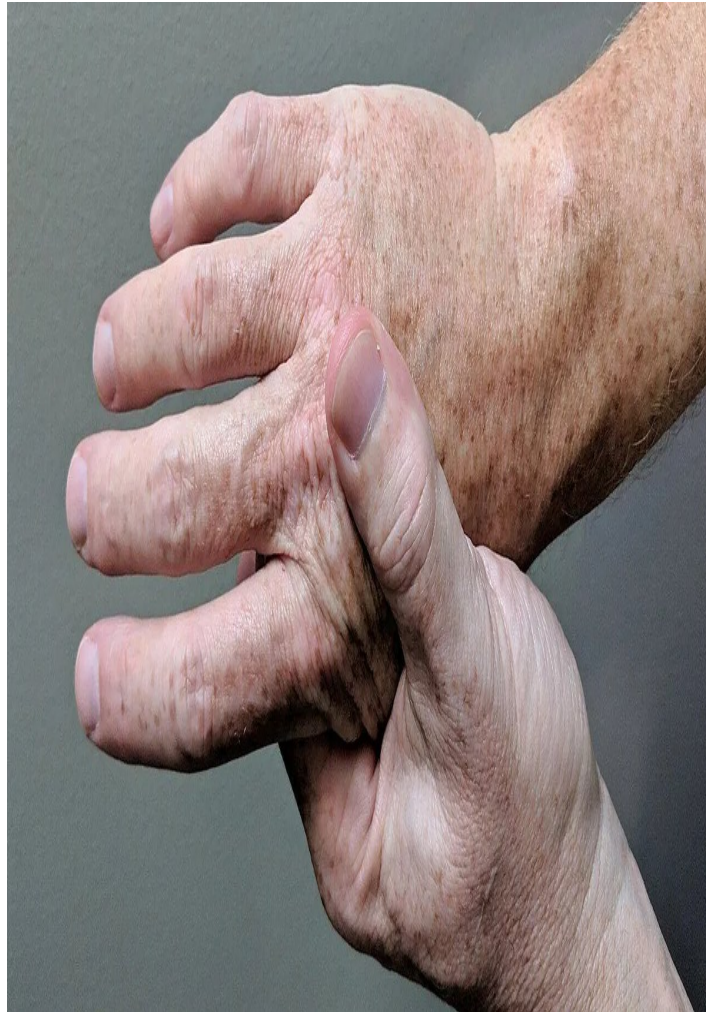
By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-12 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Waiting for an NHS rheumatology appointment can feel frustrating and worrying — especially when you're in pain. Current waiting times in the UK range from **6 weeks to over 6 months** depending on your area. Here's what you can do to manage while you wait, and how to potentially speed up the process.

Current Waiting Times

NHS England targets a maximum 18-week wait from GP referral to first consultant appointment. In practice, many rheumatology departments are significantly longer due to high demand and workforce shortages.

How to Get Seen Faster



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- Ensure urgent referral — ask your GP to mark the referral as urgent if you have red flags (new joint swelling, systemic symptoms, or suspected inflammatory arthritis)
- Early Inflammatory Arthritis Clinics — many NHS trusts have fast-track clinics for suspected new RA. Ask your GP about these
- Choose Your Hospital — in England, you have the right to choose which hospital you're referred to. Check waiting times at nhs.uk/service-search
- Patient Initiated Follow-Up (PIFU) — if you're already under a consultant, ask about PIFU to get quicker access during flares

What to Do While Waiting

Self-Management

- Keep a symptom diary — note pain levels, affected joints, morning stiffness duration, and medications used
- Take photographs of any visible swelling — useful evidence for your appointment
- Try the anti-inflammatory diet — Mediterranean-style eating can help
- Stay as active as possible with gentle exercise

Pain Management with Your GP

- Your GP can prescribe pain relief while you wait
- Ask about physiotherapy referral — you can start this before seeing rheumatology
- Blood tests can be arranged by your GP to monitor inflammation markers

Prepare for Your Appointment

- Write down all your symptoms, when they started, and how they affect you
- List all medications (including supplements and over-the-counter drugs)
- Bring your symptom diary and photos of swollen joints
- Note family history of arthritis or autoimmune conditions
- Write down questions you want to ask

Your Rights



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Under the NHS Constitution, you have the right to:

- Start treatment within 18 weeks of referral (in England)
- Choose your hospital or clinic
- Be told about waiting times before being referred
- Contact the Patient Advice and Liaison Service (PALS) if you have concerns about waiting times

Early treatment of inflammatory arthritis produces the best outcomes. If you believe you're waiting too long, advocate for yourself — contact PALS or ask your GP to escalate the referral.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about rheumatology waiting times – what you can do?

Short answer: NHS rheumatology waiting times vary, ranging from six weeks to over six months, with many departments exceeding the 18-week target from GP referral to first appointment. You can ask your GP for an urgent referral, inquire about fast-track clinics for suspected inflammatory arthritis, and use the NHS website to choose a hospital with shorter waiting times.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk